

DRUG-PREP

SUMMARY REPORT ON NATIONAL RESEARCH TO SCENARIO BUILDING ON THE FUTURE OF DRUGS DEVELOPMENTS IN EUROPE



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INTRODUCTION

Scenario building is a foresight method in which scenarios (different narratives of the future) are built in a collaborative way. The objective of scenario building is to explore, create and test different possible futures in order to facilitate strategic planning. It allows to be better prepared to different eventualities, including opportunities and challenges, and stimulates proactive decision making and adaptation of current actions to ensure their relevance in different possible versions of the future.

Scenarios are roadmaps that describe different possible futures, including the internal logic and trajectories leading to that future. It is important to note that scenarios are not designed to predict the future, but to explore plausible interactions between elements and how they could determine the future. The aim with scenarios is that they should be sufficiently different from one another and be internally coherent. There are many methods available to develop scenarios in foresight activities, the choice of which depends on the scope of the exercise, as well as available resources, capacity and time.

The aim of the DRUG-PREP project was to carry out foresight research at the national level to contribute to better insight and understanding of current and future trends and developments, to support greater preparedness of national drug monitoring and response systems. Between 2022 and 2024, the project partners carried out individual national foresight exercises in the six countries involved in the project: Belgium, Czechia, Finland, Ireland, the Netherlands, and Portugal. Each country performed a horizon scanning exercise. The horizon scanning approaches and results from each country are outlined in a different document, 'Summary report on country-specific insights based on horizon scanning' (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2025a) and the lessons learnt are presented in the 'Summary report on recommendations and best practices for national implementation of foresight strategies' (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2025b).

In addition to horizon scanning, scenario building exercises were carried out Belgium, Ireland and Finland, but due to capacity constraints, it was not possible to carry out scenario building in all countries. The final meeting of the DRUG-PREP project took place in the context of the Reitox Academy on Futures, in which scenario building methods were introduced to the participants. The scenario building exercises carried out in DRUG-PREP had different objectives and used a variety of approaches, which provides opportunities to identify several lessons learnt. This document presents the case studies of scenario building in DRUG-PREP and reflects on some lessons learnt and next steps.

SCENARIO BUILDING IN DRUG-PREP



Belgium

In Belgium, a scenario building exercise was carried out in February 2024. A report of the exercise is available (Cosgrove et al., 2024). The scope of the scenario building was to explore different possible scenarios after a clear disrupting event, the ban of opium production in Afghanistan brought into force in 2022, focusing in particular on the impacts for people who use heroin in Belgium. The methodology for scenario building by the humanitarian analysis organisation ACAPS was used as a basis for the exercise (ACAPS, 2022). A short summary of the methodology is included below.

A scenario building workshop took place over 3 hours and included 15 experts from across the drugs field with different expertise, including harm reduction, security, customs, healthcare, academia and policymakers.

The workshop started by providing a baseline state of affairs of heroin use and existing trends in Belgium. This covered the most recent figures on the estimates of people who use heroin, people in treatment for a heroin use disorder, and figures on offences related to possession of heroin. On the supply side, the figures of wholesale heroin market and seizures, as well as retail heroin market, price and purity were presented.

The state of affairs also included a short presentation on lessons learnt from three previous experiences:

- The Australian heroin shortage of 2000-2001 (Day et al., 2003; Degenhardt et al., 2006; Farrell & Thorne, 2005; Maher et al., 2007; Topp et al., 2003; Weatherburn et al., 2003; Wood et al., 2006)
- The Taliban poppy cultivation ban in Afghanistan in the early 2000s (Caulkins et al., 2024)
- The heroin shortage of 2010-2011 in the UK and Europe (EMCDDA, 2011; Hallam, 2011; Harris et al., 2015; Mital et al., 2016)

After the state of affairs, participants received an introduction to scenario building and the approach that would be taken in the workshop. Participants were then divided into two groups to collaboratively build scenarios. The research question was:

“What effects could the Afghanistan opium ban have in Belgium within the next 2 years? What futures could we expect?”

Both groups started from the basis of one key uncertainty: the availability (or not) of heroin in Belgium. Starting from that key uncertainty, the groups developed mini-scenarios by combining assumptions following the framework of: current drivers, future drivers, vulnerability/resilience of the affected population, national response capacity.

Using nominal group technique, workshop participants were given five minutes for independent thinking based on the research question. They were then asked to share one idea at a time. Starting from each idea, scenarios were constructed by considering each aspect of the guiding framework in turn, in particular considering cause-and-effect relationships between assumptions and variables. Participants were encouraged to think “out-of-the-box” and to consider opposite possibilities when an assumption was put forward. Once all the aspects of a mini-scenario had been considered, the workshop facilitator asked a different participant to put forward an assumption that they had written down, based on which another mini-scenario was built.

The mini-scenarios developed in each group were presented back to the whole group. Both groups developed six mini-scenarios, creating 12 mini-scenarios in total. A voting session took place via an online platform, in which participants individually ranked each mini-scenario based on two criteria: certainty (mini-scenario is likely to happen or not) and risk (mini-scenario has a low or high risk).

Following the scenario building workshop, the mini-scenarios were compared by the research team. Mini-scenarios that were similar were combined and compounding factors were identified. The combined scenarios based on the results of the workshop were:

1. **Market adaptation:** The market adapts, with new production routes meaning supply remains stable in Belgium with heroin of different qualities.
2. **Increased vulnerability of people who use heroin:** A lack of heroin leads to increased vulnerability of people who use heroin (e.g. risky behaviours, crime, aggression).
3. **Switch to synthetic opioids:** Synthetic opioids fill the gap in the market due to a lack of heroin, leading to an increase in fatal and non-fatal overdoses.
4. **Switch to medicalised depressants:** A lack of heroin causes increases in the use of medicalised depressants (e.g. opiate agonist therapy, benzodiazepines) on both the legal and illegal market.
5. **Switch to stimulants:** A lack of heroin causes people to switch to stimulants such as synthetic cathinones, crack cocaine or methamphetamines.

It is important to note that the scenarios did not aim to be exhaustive or to predict the future. Each scenario included a narrative description, the potential impacts on the affected population and implications for national response capacity. Readers are invited to consult the full report of the exercise for more details (Cosgrove et al., 2024).

Finally, recommendations were developed based on the different scenarios. The overarching recommendations were to: (A) Improve monitoring to rapidly detect developments of the drug situation and (B) Ensure capacity of harm reduction and healthcare to deal with new emerging challenges. The aim of the recommendations was to outline actions that are needed at the present time by different parties, in order to rapidly detect changes. Based on how the future develops, specific actions would be needed relevant to that scenario.



The scenario-building exercise carried out in Finland is described in Unlu et al (2024). An expert group was brought together as part of the foresight activities in the drugs field in Finland, which included horizon scanning, trend analysis and scenario building, with each activity building off the previous one.

To build scenarios, the expert group initially established a 'baseline' scenario, envisaging a future that assumes an absence of major disruptions. This involved identifying key trends driving the anticipated future. The expert panel identified 11 key trends related to illicit drug use. These trends were then evaluated and ranked based on two criteria: likelihood of occurring and potential impact. In the next phase, the participants developed future scenarios based on the highest-ranked trends.

The group evaluated the divergence between trends and drivers based on their uncertainty levels. Expert groups explored plausible scenarios by focusing on uncertainties in the baseline scenario. The outcomes of the scenario building exercise were categorised into three main themes:

- 1. Changing drug attitudes and increasing prevalence of drug use**
- 2. Insufficient health services**
- 3. Diversification of drug sale and production**

Based on these scenarios, strategies were developed for addressing rising drug use, access barriers, and new sale methods. The authors note that "the study emphasises the need for Finland to reform its drug policy, advocating harm reduction, decriminalization, and public health-focused strategies. It suggests implementing needle exchanges, safe consumption spaces, and decriminalizing drug possession, alongside enhanced addiction treatment and preventive education" (Unlu et al., 2024). Such participatory approaches are advised in policymaking to address the complex nature of drug issues, particularly in the context of synthetic and polydrug use (Unlu et al., 2024).



In Ireland, a scenario development workshop was organised in the context of the National Drugs Forum 2023. The aim of the workshop at the National Drugs Forum was to develop futures literacy among the forum participants by working with the notions of uncertainty and scenarios. The discussion held at the workshop revolved around the future of the problem substance use among young people in Ireland in 2040, in order to identify potential future threats and to explore ideas and recommendations regarding response activities.

The workshop organisers used the Rip van Winkle technique, in which participants are asked to imagine awakening from a sleep of several years and ask a number of questions about the world they find themselves in. Each question has 'yes' or 'no' answer and they reveal aspects of the what the questioner is uncertain about. This was done using an online survey of registered participants in the National Drugs Forum.

The survey identified a list of uncertainties, that were then arranged into 14 topic clusters. These defined the framework drivers of change for the workshop. Two extreme outcomes were assigned for each uncertainty cluster and the participants in the workshop were asked to select two uncertainties to construct the scenario matrix. Using these two key uncertainties, each group in the workshop prepared four scenario snapshots using a 2x2 matrix. Nine separate groups participated in the workshop, and each of them created scenarios based on the two key uncertainties they selected.

There was considerable variety in the key drivers chosen to develop the scenarios. The table below presents a sample of some of the scenarios arrived at during the workshop.

The aim of the exercise was to build futures literacy among participants. It was noted that while the workshop at the National Drugs Forum was a brief and limited exercise in strategic foresight, it confirmed that that was interest and enthusiasm among stakeholders in engaging in this work and agreement on the relevance of foresight concepts to prepare for uncertainty in a complex and challenging policy area.

Table 1: Sample of scenarios developed during a scenario development workshop in Ireland

Uncertainties selected	Examples of scenarios developed
• Harm and safety • Support services	The quadrant at which a regulated market and good availability of services presented a hopeful scenario in which deaths and crime were reduced, and mental health services were capable of dealing with consequences of increased use. A much bleaker scenario was envisaged in the lower left quadrant with a health and law enforcement service unable to cope with loose regulation. Another table saw the combination of increased regulation and limited services as a recipe for social and economic upheaval. Regulation can increase safety but only in a situation where there is equality of access to services.
• Harm and safety • Funding, research and policy	In a regulated environment, in which research is well supported, there will be a reduction in harms as a result in increasing capacity to identify emerging trends and share learning between service providers. While the opposite quadrant describes increasing harms and a lack of knowledge, there are increased opportunities for communities to organise and advocate for change.
• Harm and safety • Family and community	Where a lack of support for communities is combined with looser regulation, the lack of infrastructure will mean exploitation of vulnerable groups, poor information and disorganised harm reduction services. A different combination sees less criminal conviction and more support for those dependant on drugs closer to their own homes.
• Prevalence and trends • Innovation in treatment	A drugs market dominated by synthetic drugs and where highly advanced treatment modes are available could see a much greater availability of new drugs, but the AI, on which much treatment will depend, will make critical information available quickly and reduce harms. However, if treatment does not advance, a high prevalence of synthetic drugs could have severe consequences and a collapse in harm reduction services. Another table that worked with these two uncertainties concluded that more effective services may result in less reluctance to use novel drugs, but the harms could be offset by extensive drug checking in a more regulated market.
• Innovations in treatment • Regulation, legalization and criminal sanction	Without changes to the legal status of drugs, even highly effective treatment will have reduced impact as people may be reluctant to enter treatment. There will be an increase in short term treatment and use of emergency services and highly medicalised approach to treatment. Where conventional treatments have become less effective, slow change in the regulatory environment will mean clients presenting with more complex health needs, a sharp upturn in drug deaths and severe social dislocation.



On 27-28 June 2024, a Reitox Academy¹ was organised in Dublin, Ireland, on the future of synthetic drug use. The meeting was co-organised by the European Union Drugs Agency (EUDA) and DRUG-PREP, specifically the Health Research Board (HRB) as the Irish NFP and DRUG-PREP partner. The meeting was facilitated 4CF The Futures Literacy Company.

A total of 28 participants from 14 countries attended (Belgium, Bulgaria, Croatia, Cyprus, Finland, Germany, Greece, Hungary, Ireland, Latvia, Lithuania, Netherlands, Poland, Portugal). The attendees included people familiar with foresight methodologies as well as people with no previous experience.

The objectives of the Reitox Academy on futures were to support the Reitox network by:

- Enhancing futures literacy of participants by working with the notions of uncertainty, projections and scenarios.
- Experimenting with selected methods and tools in a structured foresight process concerning the future of synthetic drugs use.
- Facilitating the development of alternative scenario snapshots of the synthetic drugs use in a 20-year perspective, and collecting insights regarding potential future opportunities, threats and policy (or research) responses.
- Understanding the use and the role of scenarios in the strategy & decision-making processes.

Scenario building during the Reitox Academy was done using the 2x2 matrix methodology (Rhydderch, 2017), which pairs two drivers to create axes in a 2x2 matrix as the basis for possible scenarios. The steps followed were:

1. Identifying driving factors of the future of synthetic drugs use (Rip van Winkle exercise)
2. Clustering of driving factors
3. Selection of two key uncertainties
4. Development of scenarios
5. Identification of challenges and opportunities of each scenario
6. Development of policy recommendations for each scenario

The scenarios were developed by combining two drivers: regulation and availability of synthetic drugs. Four scenarios were developed by four different groups. Subsequently, the wind-tunnelling method was used to go from scenarios to strategy. Using the wind-tunnelling method, each group imagined that the world was as described in their scenario. They then looked at each of the strategic priorities of the EU Drugs Strategy to determine if they would be relevant in the scenario or if they would require modification. This method explores how future-proof the strategy is.

¹ The Reitox network brings together the national focal points (NFPs) for drug monitoring and data collection. The Reitox Academy is a training programme which addresses the training and information needs of the EUDA's national partners

CONCLUSION & LESSONS LEARNT

In conclusion, this report outlines the various scenario-building activities conducted during the DRUG-PREP project, highlighting the diversity of approaches that can be employed depending on factors such as the topic, capacity, timeframe, and desired outcomes. The exercises in DRUG-PREP provided useful introductions to scenario building and offered important lessons for future initiatives. Some key strengths emerged from these exercises. For instance, all the scenario building exercises employed participatory approaches that ensured viewpoints from different types of expertise were considered, but also helped to promote a forward-thinking mindset among participants who were previously not introduced to foresight methods. The different exercises provide a snapshot of different methods available for researchers looking to employ scenario building.

The experiences also provide valuable lessons learnt on the challenges of using scenario building in foresight. A key lesson was the importance of clearly defining the objectives of the exercise at the outset. For example, goals can include answering a specific research question, building capacity among stakeholders, testing strategies, or carrying out an exploratory exercise. It is important to clearly define the objectives prior to starting the project, as this will drive the choice of time horizon and specific methodology used. Having methodological clarity, including an appropriate time horizon, ensures that the exercise remains aligned with its intended purpose. Having a very specific research question (as opposed to carrying out an exploratory exercise) can facilitate stakeholder engagement and achievement of tangible outcomes, however the exploratory benefits of foresight in exploring the improbable or unimaginable should not be undervalued.

A second lesson learnt was that the outcomes of scenario-building are heavily influenced by the stakeholders involved and the researchers facilitating the process. Including a diverse group of stakeholders with varying expertise and viewpoints enriches the scenarios and ensures a more comprehensive exploration of potential futures. Stakeholder engagement can be facilitated by having a clearly defined and achievable objectives, as well as expected outcomes that are relevant to stakeholders. This not only enhances the quality of the scenarios but also fosters greater engagement and buy-in from participants.

Finally, adequate time is a critical factor in the success of scenario-building exercises. Due to time and resource constraints scenario building was not carried out in all the countries in the project. Additionally, the scenario building exercises that were carried out had relatively limited time available (typically only one workshop per country), which may have constrained the depth and detail of the scenarios developed. To conduct more thorough and impactful scenario-building, significantly more time is needed to allow for deeper exploration and validation of the scenarios. Additionally, scenario building should

not be seen as a “one-time exercise” – the scenarios should be revisited and refined. The time and resources required for a fruitful foresight exercise should not be underestimated. Nevertheless, the experiences were a useful introduction to scenario building for the involved teams.

Looking ahead, the next steps include leveraging these insights at the European level and refining research questions that deserve additional attention at the EU and national level. Increasing experience and investing in capacity building in scenarios across European countries, including the different approaches and supporting tools that can be used, will be essential to continue developing effective foresight practices.

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